

Professional & Academic English Writing

**An Intensive 4-Week Independent Study
Course for Chinese University Students**



**Last Course Update: 4 April 2020
Course Instructor: Christopher M. Palasz**

Table of Contents

Table of Contents.....	1
About the Course Instructor.....	2
Before You Begin.....	2
English Level Expectations.....	2
Who is this for?.....	3
Course Style, Foundations, and Flexibility.....	3
Course Introduction.....	4
Course Schedule.....	4
Goals & Outcomes.....	5
Final Portfolio.....	5
Passing the Course.....	6
Tips for Success.....	7
Helpful Online Resources.....	8
Instructions.....	9
Week 1: Introduction Week.....	10
W1 Day 1: Plagiarism part 1.....	11
W1 Day 2: Plagiarism part 2.....	35
W1 Day 3: Mini-Essay part 1.....	37
W1 Day 4: Mini-Essay part 2.....	38
W1 Day 5: Adding Sources.....	50
W1 Day 6-7: Editing & Reformatting.....	51
Week 2: Getting Started With The Project.....	54
W2 Day 1: Choosing a Topic.....	55
W2 Day 2: Essay Organization.....	58
W2 Day 3: Using an Outline.....	69
W2 Day 4: The Thesis Statement.....	73
W2 Day 5: Writing the Body & Using Sources.....	81
W2 Day 6-7: Writing the Introduction & Being Explicit.....	87
Week 3: Completing The Project.....	91
W3 Day 1: Smoothing It Over.....	92
W3 Day 2: Writing a Conclusion part 1.....	108
W3 Day 3: Conclusion part 2 & Getting Outside Feedback.....	117
W3 Day 4: Adjusting the Format.....	118
W3 Day 5: Practice Exercises part 1.....	129
W3 Day 6-7: Practice Exercises part 2.....	132
Week 4: Project Final Review & Presentation.....	135
W4 Day 1: (optional).....	136
W4 Day 2: Project Assessment.....	137
W4 Day 3: Project Revision.....	138
W4 Day 4: How to Create a Presentation of the Completed Project.....	139
W4 Day 5: Pre-Writing for the PowerPoint Presentation.....	149
W4 Day 6: Recording & Revising the Presentation.....	150
W4 Day 7: Assessment & Course Feedback Survey.....	151
End of Course.....	155

Curriculum Design Portfolio Sample

Professional & Academic English Writing

Historical front matter The original 2020 cover and table of contents have been preserved on the preceding two pages at the designer's request. The original contents page reflects the complete 158-page course. This curated portfolio edition begins here and replaces the remainder.

Designed as an intensive four-week independent-study course for Chinese university students preparing for English-medium academic work. The course scaffolds learners from source use and thesis development through drafting, feedback, revision, presentation, and portfolio reflection.

Project at a glance

Audience Chinese university students with intermediate-to-advanced English proficiency

Format Independent study; approximately two hours per day, six days per week, for four weeks

Designer role Needs researcher, curriculum designer, content developer, and assessment designer

Design basis Self-regulated learning, process writing, project-based learning, and academic-writing research

Final products Source-supported essay, revision evidence, recorded slide presentation, and reflective portfolio

Original development Graduate course project completed during MA studies in English Rhetoric, 2020

What this sample demonstrates

- Audience-centered course planning and documented design constraints
- Scaffolded learning progression across a multi-week course
- Alignment among outcomes, practice, feedback, and assessment
- Supports for independent and multilingual learners

CASE STUDY

Challenge and Design Context

The learner need

The target learners had substantial experience studying English but varied experience with source-supported academic writing. Because the course was designed for independent study, learners could not rely on frequent instructor explanation, reminders, or feedback. The materials therefore needed to make the process visible, divide a complex writing project into manageable tasks, and help learners monitor their own progress.

Evidence informing the design

The original course states that its development was informed by a designer-conducted survey of more than 800 Chinese university students about self-study habits, as well as research in English rhetoric, academic literacy, writing across disciplines, and self-regulated learning. The source document does not report formal course-completion or learning-outcome data, so this portfolio sample presents the design evidence without claiming measured impact.

Key constraints

- No routine instructor interaction or individualized feedback
- English-only final products for learners working across languages
- An intensive four-week schedule with a substantial final project
- A need to balance structure with learner choice and autonomy
- A need to teach writing, research, revision, and presentation in one coherent experience

Design response Use short daily deliverables, predictable reflection prompts, visible weekly checklists, staged drafting, delayed final revision, and multiple opportunities for self- and peer-generated feedback.

DESIGN RATIONALE

Learning Framework

Self-regulated learning

Each study day ends with the same concise reflection cycle: learners record time spent, judge difficulty, identify what worked, name a weakness, and plan an adjustment for the next session. Repetition turns reflection into a routine rather than an occasional add-on.

Process writing

The course treats writing as an iterative process. Learners select a topic, research, outline, draft the body, write the introduction and conclusion, step away from the draft, seek feedback, and revise. Major decisions are revisited instead of treated as final on the first attempt.

Project-based learning

Daily tasks contribute to one authentic project rather than a series of unrelated exercises. The completed essay becomes the source for a slide presentation and a final portfolio, giving learners a clear purpose for the work produced throughout the course.

Intentional pacing

- Week-opening tasks are lighter and emphasize planning.
- High-production tasks occur after learners have built the necessary foundation.
- A scheduled break creates distance from the draft before final revision.
- The four-week course can expand to eight weeks when learners need more processing time.

Portfolio modernization The 2026 edition uses more measurable outcomes, model-light supports, current citation language, accessible formatting, and an explicit responsible-AI policy while preserving the original course architecture.

COURSE ARCHITECTURE

Four-Week Learning Progression

The sequence moves from a low-stakes diagnostic task to a complete research project, then converts the written work into an oral and visual product.

Week	Primary focus	Key learning work	Evidence produced
1	Foundations and diagnostic practice	Plagiarism awareness; mini-essay; source integration; reflection	Revised 400-600 word mini-essay
2	Plan and draft the project	Topic and audience; research; outline; thesis; body; introduction	Complete first draft without conclusion
3	Complete and strengthen	Transitions; cohesion; conclusion; peer review; formatting; focused practice	Complete draft plus peer-feedback request
4	Assess, revise, and present	Self-review; peer feedback; final revision; slide planning; recording	Final essay, presentation, and reflection

Course-level learning outcomes

- Define an appropriate audience and focused research topic.
- Locate and evaluate credible sources for relevance and authority.
- Develop an outline and defensible working thesis.
- Integrate source material with accurate attribution and original analysis.
- Revise a source-supported essay using self-assessment and peer feedback.
- Adapt written research into an organized visual presentation.

Design principle Every week ends with visible evidence of progress toward the final portfolio.

ALIGNMENT

Outcomes, Practice, and Evidence

The alignment map shows how course activities prepare learners for the evidence used in self- and peer-assessment.

Outcome area	Learning practice	Evidence of learning
Topic and audience	Need-based topic questions; audience analysis	Focused topic statement and research question
Source evaluation	Credibility checks; three-source research plan	Annotated source plan and accurate citations
Organization and thesis	Outline; thesis alternatives; paragraph planning	Working thesis and structured draft
Evidence integration	Point-evidence-explanation practice; source-to-analysis prompts	Body paragraphs integrating evidence and writer reasoning
Revision	Read-aloud review; self-checklist; peer-feedback form	Revision plan, revised essay, and reflection
Presentation	Content selection; slide outline; rehearsal; recording review	Recorded presentation and self-assessment

Assessment pattern

- **Diagnostic:** an initially under-specified mini-essay reveals current habits and becomes material for revision.
- **Formative:** daily reflections, checklists, short exercises, and draft milestones guide adjustment.
- **Collaborative:** peer feedback tests whether a reader can follow the writer's purpose and reasoning.
- **Summative:** the final portfolio combines the essay, presentation, and reflective evidence of revision.

Why the sequence matters The assessment system does not wait until the final day to identify problems. Learners produce reviewable evidence at each stage and use it to make the next decision.

SAMPLE MODULE

Week 2: From Topic to Draft

Week 2 begins the main course project. By the end of the week, learners have a researched, organized draft with an introduction, thesis, and body paragraphs. The conclusion is intentionally reserved for the following week so that learners can revisit the direction of the paper after drafting.

Module outcomes

- Choose a focused topic connected to a genuine question or need.
- Locate at least three credible and relevant sources.
- Organize ideas in an outline and write a working thesis.
- Draft body paragraphs that connect evidence to original analysis.
- Write an introduction after the direction of the paper is clear.

Day	Focus	Required evidence
1	Topic and audience	Topic statement + research question
2	Organization and brainstorming	Idea bank + draft structure
3	Credible sources and outline	Three-source plan + outline
4	Working thesis	Three thesis attempts + selected version
5	Body paragraphs and evidence	Body draft
6	Introduction and explicit connections	Introduction + revised transitions
7	Recovery or rest day	Catch up only if needed

Learner support Each day identifies one required product. Learners can see what 'finished for today' means without needing instructor clarification.

SAMPLE LEARNING ACTIVITY 1

Topic, Audience, and Research Question

Purpose Move from a broad interest to a focused, researchable question with a clear reason for writing.

Estimated time 45-60 minutes

Deliverable A topic statement, intended audience, and one working research question

Procedure

1. List three issues, needs, or questions connected to your studies, work, family, community, or future plans.
2. For each possibility, write what you genuinely want to understand and why the answer could matter to someone else.
3. Choose one possibility and identify the audience most likely to use or care about the information.
4. Turn the topic into an open research question. Avoid questions that can be answered with only yes, no, or a single fact.
5. Run the question through the success check below and revise it once before beginning source research.

Success check

- The question is narrow enough for one essay but complex enough to require research.
- The audience and purpose are identifiable.
- Credible evidence is likely to exist.
- The question leaves room for analysis rather than simple reporting.

Model-light support The activity provides decision criteria and a process, not a complete sentence for learners to copy. This reduces the risk that a model replaces the learner's original thinking.

Reflection prompt

What made you choose this question, and what might make it difficult to answer well?

SAMPLE LEARNING ACTIVITY 2

Source Plan and Working Thesis

Purpose Build a defensible claim from credible evidence while keeping the writer's reasoning visible.

Estimated time 75-90 minutes

Deliverable A three-source plan, brief outline, and selected working thesis

Part A: Source plan

Source	Credibility check	Planned use
Source 1	Authority or expertise	How it may support, complicate, or challenge the paper
Source 2	Currency and relevance	How it may support, complicate, or challenge the paper
Source 3	Evidence quality	How it may support, complicate, or challenge the paper

Part B: Working thesis

Write three possible thesis statements. Each attempt should make a specific claim, show the direction of the paper, and leave room for evidence and analysis. Select the strongest attempt, then explain why it is the best starting point.

Attempt 1: _____

Attempt 2: _____

Attempt 3: _____

Selected thesis and rationale: _____

Revision expectation The thesis is a working decision, not a contract. Learners return to it after drafting and again during final revision.

FEEDBACK SYSTEM

Reflection, Peer Review, and Revision

Feedback is built into the workflow rather than added after the writing is complete.

Revision cycle

1. **Draft:** produce a complete version before attempting line-by-line perfection.
2. **Self-review:** read the work aloud and identify strengths, gaps, and unclear connections.
3. **Peer feedback:** ask a reader to summarize the argument and point to specific evidence.
4. **Revision plan:** choose high-impact changes before editing individual sentences.
5. **Final revision:** address purpose, organization, evidence, and clarity, then proofread.

Daily self-regulation prompts

- How much focused time did I spend today?
- What felt easy or difficult, and why?
- What did I do effectively?
- Where did I lose time, confidence, or clarity?
- What adjustment will I make in the next session?

Focused peer-review prompts

- In one or two sentences, what do you think this paper is trying to establish?
- Identify one strong point and explain what makes it effective.
- Where did you become uncertain, unconvinced, or curious? Point to the exact passage.
- What question should the writer answer during revision?
- Recommend one high-priority change. Do not rewrite the paper for the writer.

Feedback boundary The reviewer describes the reading experience and provides evidence. The writer retains responsibility for decisions and wording.

ASSESSMENT DESIGN

Analytic Essay Rubric

This redesign replaces the original unanchored yes/no scale with observable performance descriptions. The complete course could add weights or convert levels to points based on the instructional setting.

Criterion	Beginning	Developing	Proficient	Strong
Purpose and organization	Purpose or thesis is difficult to identify; sections feel disconnected.	Purpose is present but broad; organization is uneven.	Clear thesis and logical organization guide the reader.	Specific, compelling purpose; organization strengthens the reasoning.
Evidence integration	Sources are missing, weak, or inserted without explanation.	Relevant evidence appears, but connections or attribution are inconsistent.	Credible evidence is attributed and explained in relation to the claim.	Evidence is synthesized, evaluated, and integrated with the writer's analysis.
Reasoning and development	Claims rely mainly on assertion or summary.	Some analysis is present but may be repetitive or incomplete.	Reasoning develops the claim with relevant explanation and examples.	Analysis addresses complexity, alternatives, and implications with precision.
Revision and clarity	Major problems interfere with meaning; little evidence of revision.	Meaning is generally clear; revision addresses some larger concerns.	Revision improves focus, cohesion, sentence clarity, and correctness.	Revision choices are substantial, purposeful, and consistently polished.

How the rubric is used

- Before peer review, learners select one criterion that needs the most attention.
- After feedback, learners cite specific rubric language in a revision plan.
- At the end, learners provide one piece of evidence for each self-rating.

Assessment principle A score should summarize evidence, not replace feedback. Performance descriptions make the next revision decision more visible.

FINAL PERFORMANCE TASK

From Research Paper to Presentation

The final week asks learners to revise the paper using self- and peer-generated evidence, then adapt the research for a new mode and audience. The presentation is not a reading of the paper; it requires selection, visual support, rehearsal, and reflection.

Portfolio deliverables

- Final source-supported academic essay
- Working outline and source plan
- Peer feedback and revision plan
- Slide presentation and recorded delivery
- Final reflection explaining growth and next steps

Presentation success criteria

Criterion	Observable evidence
Content selection	Prioritizes the purpose, main evidence, and implications rather than reproducing every section of the paper
Visual design	Uses readable, relevant visuals that support the spoken explanation
Delivery	Communicates clearly at an appropriate pace with evidence of rehearsal
Source use	Attributes key ideas and evidence in both slides and spoken delivery
Reflection	Reviews the recording and identifies specific improvements for a second attempt

Transfer of learning Adapting the essay into a presentation requires learners to reorganize knowledge for a different purpose, audience, and communication mode.

2026 MODERNIZATION AND REFLECTION

What I Would Retain and Improve

Design decisions to retain

- One authentic project developed through visible daily milestones
- A predictable reflection routine that supports independent study
- Multiple revision passes separated by time and outside feedback
- A final portfolio that preserves evidence of process, not only the finished product

Improvements in a current implementation

- Replace reproduced readings with original micro-lessons and links to current, accessible sources.
- Use MLA 9 or a clearly selected disciplinary style rather than requiring conversion between formats as a stand-alone exercise.
- Permit strategic multilingual planning while requiring original English-language final products.
- Add captions, alt text, accessible headings, and digital forms with clear keyboard navigation.
- State responsible-AI boundaries: brainstorming and feedback may be allowed with disclosure; generated writing may not substitute for the learner's own analysis.
- Pilot the course and collect completion, revision, and learner-experience evidence before making impact claims.

Selected foundations

Designer-conducted needs survey of 800+ Chinese university students (course-development research, 2019-2020).

Rosenwasser, David, and Jill Stephen. *Writing Analytically*. Cengage, 2019.

Wyrick, Jean. *Cheng Gong Xie Zuo Ru Men = Steps to Writing Well*. Bei Jing Da Xue Chu Ban She, 2016.

Zimmerman, Barry J. 'Becoming a Self-Regulated Learner: An Overview.' *Theory Into Practice*, vol. 41, no. 2, 2002, pp. 64-70.

Modern Language Association. *MLA Handbook*. 9th ed., 2021.

Portfolio note This curated sample presents original course architecture, activities, and assessment design. Extended third-party readings from the 2020 source course have been intentionally omitted.